the IPL and even in the 2010 Champions League Twenty20 that Dhoni had won. This World Cup, it was argued, would be no different.

There's many a slip

We won our next two pool matches against Ireland and the Netherlands fairly comfortably and met South Africa in Nagpur on 12 March 2011. It was this match that in many ways turned our campaign on its head. We began well and were soon firmly in control. Sehwag and I got off to a quick start – I scored my ninety-ninth international century in this match, but it was not much talked about at the time because the focus was squarely on the World Cup – and we set South Africa a target of 297 after a dramatic batting collapse, losing nine wickets in the last ten overs, with Steyn getting a five-for. Eventually we lost the match with two balls of the South African innings remaining and the defeat hurt us badly.

Unsurprisingly, there was stinging criticism in the media. We had slipped once but we all knew we could not afford to slip again. We simply had to get the campaign back on track in the next match, against the West Indies in Chennai on 20 March, and we managed to do just that, thanks to a Yuvraj Singh century and a surprise slower ball from Zaheer Khan to dismiss the in-form Devon Smith for 81. The crucial knockout phase was about to begin and in the quarter-final at Ahmedabad we drew Australia, the defending champions.

Spicing up practice

It was on the eve of that West Indies match that I tried to introduce an element of fun into my batting practice. I was practising to some throw-downs from Gary Kirsten and was just about to wrap up the session when the idea came to me. I decided to close my eyes for six deliveries, just after the bowler released the ball, then I asked Gary if he had noticed anything different. Gary said he hadn't, except that my head was staying up when I was driving. I had to keep my head steady, because with your eyes shut you can easily lose the path of the ball with a very slight movement of the head. When I told him I'd had my eyes closed, he was shocked. I explained that I had watched his wrist position when he released the ball, to see if it was, say, an outswinger, and then closed my eyes and visualized the path the ball would travel. After that I went a step further by keeping my eyes shut and telling the fielders where I had